

Queen Mary University of London CoARA action plan

Preamble

Queen Mary University of London joined Coalition on Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in 2022. Our action plan captures the activity that has taken place across the university since then, drawing it together into a programme of work which we will review, iterate and develop to enhance the ways we promote and engage with responsible research assessment (RRA).

CoARA Principle	Guidance points from CoARA	Action	Timeframe
Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	• How does your organisation plan to enable recognition of more diverse contributions to research? • How does your organisation plan to enable greater diversity in career paths and profiles?	• Through our R&I awards, we recognise the diversity of contributions to research, including from PS and technicians, alongside ECRs. The award criteria embed our commitments to responsible research assessment and DORA.	Ongoing
		• Enhance our commitment to increasing diversity in our researcher pipeline, and to sharing our best practice with other institutions.	Ongoing
		• Progress the technicians commitment action plan, including our commitment	Ongoing

		to supporting technical career development. • Review and make improvements to the ways we recognise a wide range of research and innovation activities (including contributions to Impact/KE, responsible research, and to research culture). • Conduct training sessions and activities to expand researchers' understandings of diverse career paths, with tailored sessions for different groups, specifically referencing HR excellence in research • Continue work to recognise all contributions to outputs via the Credit taxonomy, and develop the integration between systems and processes to capture this	In place by September 2026 Ongoing Ongoing
Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation	• How does your organisation plan to actively engage in and	• Affirm our commitment to using narrative	Ongoing

for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	learn from research on research work? • How does your organisation plan to accommodate qualitative evaluation mechanisms and base the use of metrics in a way that is aligned with your organisation's value system?	submissions to support appraisal and probation. • Embed peer review as the basis of selection of outputs and impact case studies for REF. • Develop and/or deliver training to increase recognition of open research and its value • Encourage, monitor and support the University's Open Research Policies • Keep abreast of and actively review Research on Research and Innovation to identify insights we can use.	Ongoing Ongoing Ongoing Ongoing
Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	• How does your organisation plan to mitigate reliance on JIF and h-index?	• Ensure unconscious bias training is available to all assessors of research and researchers, and additional specialist training is provided for reviewers of research	Ongoing

		outputs and impact case studies for REF. • Embed principles into training for developing and using narrative CVs	Ongoing
Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	• How does your organisation plan to mitigate reliance on organisation rankings?	• Embed principles into training for developing and using narrative CVs	Ongoing
Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	• Which resources will your institution allocate to the implementation of the research assessment reform? (Whether in terms of capacity or budget, to actively engage in the reform Journey)	• Use our preparations for REF and associated training to embed and reinforce our commitment to responsible research assessment. • Establish the Research and Innovation Operations group as the steering group for the COARA action plan, reporting through the EO R&I	Ongoing September 2025
Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	• Does your organisation plan to pilot or implement alternative/ new assessment criteria, tools, and processes (e.g. narrative CV format, competency-based CV format, evidence-based CV format, diversification of research	• Extend the mentoring support available in promotions to enhance engagement with narrative CVs, building on training we already provide to some groups (e.g. PGRs).	September 2025

	careers and associated career progression)?	- Invest resources in establishing and monitoring a more holistic view of research outputs and impacts. - Provide guidance on Open Research practices and the benefits of Open research to all research assessors, research staff and students. - Provide mentoring to postdoctoral researchers and to other researchers to support them in their academic career development.	Ongoing Ongoing Ongoing
Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	Does your institution plan to provide training, guidance and support to assessment panels, committees, and juries?	- Communicate changes in assessments through academic career pathways to all staff who will be assessed and who will undertake assessments. - Embed COARA activity into Research and Innovation Culture action plans.	Ongoing Ongoing

Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	• How does your organisation plan to exchange practices and foster exchange of good practices in national and international contexts?	• Join the National Chapter of CoARA and participate fully in sharing of best practise in research assessments • Continue working with sector bodies to share our good practice, and identify other opportunities to do so. For example, sharing our work on reasonable adjustments and training and development for PGRs, sharing case studies of postdoc support through the Vitae International Conference.	Ongoing Ongoing
Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments	• How will your organisation ensure the transparent communication of the organisation's research evaluation processes within and outside of the organisation?	• Publish CoARA Action Plan on University and CoARA webpages, along with an annual update on progress. • Deliver an annual update on activity taken and change made to Research and Innovation Board. • Disseminate our commitments to	Once approved, target autumn 2025 Once approved, target autumn 2026

		academic, technical and professional staff, providing regular updates and mechanisms for colleagues to input to the plan. • Act on feedback from each annual review to enhance and embed new processes successfully.	Once approved, target autumn 2025 Once approved, target autumn 2026
Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	• How does your institution plans to monitor and (re)evaluate its assessment criteria, tools, and processes? What will be the frequency? Who will be involved in the evaluation?	• EO R&I and Research Culture team to remain abreast of latest evidence and best practice in RRA. • Play an active role in the CoARA Coalition, Working Groups and the UK National Chapter • Continue to contribute to the UK Reproducibility Network Open and Responsible Researcher Reward and Recognition project (OR4).	Ongoing Ongoing Ongoing

